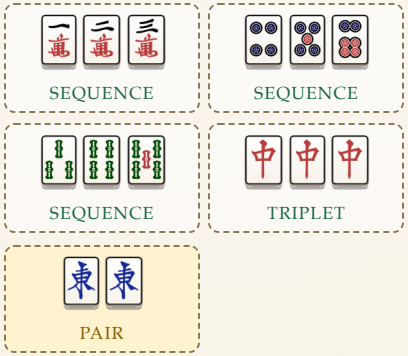
How to play *Riichi Mahjong*

A game for 4 people, a bit like rummy. For your first game you only need this side.

QUICK GUIDE · SIDE 1 OF 2

1 The goal

Build your hand: 4 sets and 1 pair.



Sequence: 3 numbers in a row from one suit. **Triplet:** 3 identical tiles. **Pair:** 2 identical.

4 × 3 + 2 = 14 tiles

2 Getting started

Four people around the table.

1. Mix the tiles face down and build a square wall together.
2. Everyone takes **13 tiles** and stands them in front of them.
3. A die decides who starts (the **dealer**). Play goes counter-clockwise.

Mix · deal · play

3 Your turn

Draw one, discard one.

1. You draw a tile from the wall.
2. You decide which one you do not need.
3. You discard it face up in front of you.

Then the player on your right goes. At the end of your turn you always hold 13 tiles.

Draw · decide · discard

4 Winning

The first to complete their hand wins.



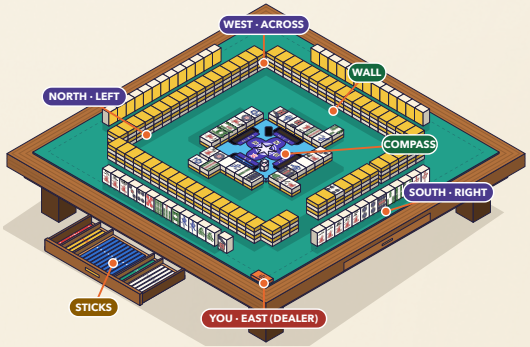
4 sets + 1 pair, using the tile you drew or the one another player just threw.

Say it out loud —**"Tsumo!"** if you drew it, **"Ron!"** if another player threw it— and show your hand.

In your first game nothing else is needed: no calls, no points. When you want more, turn the sheet over.

Tsumo! · Ron!

The table and its players



Four seats, each with a wind; the turn goes counter-clockwise: East → South → West → North.

The 34 kinds of tile *(4 copies of each)*

MANZU · NUMBERS

PINZU · CIRCLES

SOUZU · BAMBOO

HONORS · WINDS

EAST · SOUTH · WEST · NORTH

HONORS · DRAGONS

HAKU · WHITE · HATSU · GREEN · CHUN · RED

Learn and practise

rincon-riichi.vercel.app

Scan: tutorial, tiles and drills

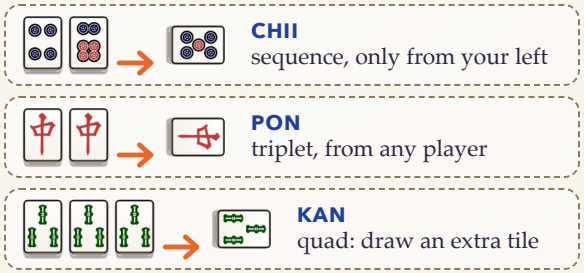
BACK: MORE RULES →

Once you have played a hand

These rules come in little by little. Add them one at a time, when someone asks "what if…?".

Calls

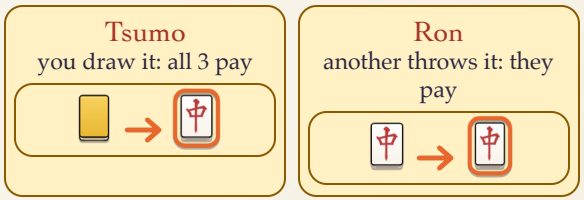
If someone throws the tile you need, you may take it.



Say it out loud and lay the set face up, with the taken tile sideways. Your hand becomes "open".

Winning properly: the yaku

Besides a complete hand you need at least 1 yaku.



Riichi — One tile from winning and no calls: discard one sideways and add a 1,000 stick.

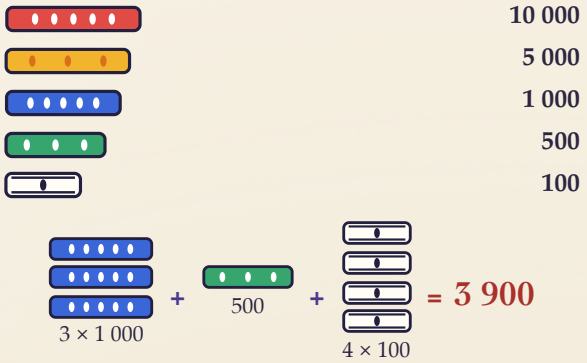
Tanyao — Only tiles from 2 to 8

Yakuhai — Triplet of dragons or of your wind

Furiten: if you already threw a tile you would win on, you cannot win by ron.

Points and sticks

Each colour is worth an amount. Everyone starts with 25,000.



When someone wins, the payer leaves the sticks on the table and the winner takes them. The value comes from **han** (yaku and dora) and **fu** (mini points).

Rounds and the end of the game

You play hand after hand, and whoever ends with the most points wins.

東 **East round** 1 2 3 4

南 **South round** 1 2 3 4

If the dealer wins they stay dealer. **If not**, the compass turns: everyone takes the next wind and the dealer passes to the right.

Tonpuusen: East round only (short). **Hanchan:** East and South (standard).

Dora and the dead wall

Bonus tiles and tiles set aside.



When the wall is opened an **indicator** is turned face up: the next tile after it is the **dora**, and each one in your hand adds 1 han. Red fives do too.

Dead wall: 14 tiles set aside (7 stacks), out of play unless someone makes a kan.

Handy words

To follow what people say at the table.

Tenpai — you are one tile from winning. Noten: you are not.

Dealer — the one who plays first (East seat).

Seat wind / round wind — yours / the current round's. Yours changes as hands pass.

Pond — your discards, face up in front of you.

Han · fu — the two measures used to count a hand.